
ACTOR PART BOOK

The Manager

a tired director — and, without trying, the audience's stand-in

Six Characters in Search of an Author

Sei personaggi in cerca d'autore · Pirandello, trans. Storer 1922

A Village Players production · Lausanne

Director: **Kiarash Jamshidi**

200 SPEECHES · 3485 WORDS ACROSS THE PLAY

WHO THE MANAGER IS

Play a director first. He runs the Village Players, he is already behind on the morning, and all day he is trying to solve the problem six strangers have walked into his rehearsal. Everything else follows from that. The audience-proxy is not something to perform — **it appears because he reacts the way they do: practically, selfishly, curiously, and too late.** He resists; he becomes curious; he tries to stage what he sees; he fails to act when action is required; he walks out claiming the day was lost. Pirandello plants him at the front of the stage so the house will recognise itself in him — but they will only do that if the actor lets it happen by itself. **Do not play *I am the audience*.** Play the tired director, honestly, and the resemblance arrives on its own.

The actor's job is to keep the audience comfortable with him for as long as possible, then keep them comfortable for one beat too long — so that when he looks at the empty Boy-chair, says *To hell with it all*, and walks out, they recognise the exit as their own. He does not stay to grieve. He does not stay to understand. He has had enough, and he leaves — exactly as the audience is about to. That is the cruelty of the ending: the Manager does the audience the favour of walking out first, and condemns them with it. Play it straight, no commentary, no irony — a tired man turning his back on a dead child and reaching for his coat. The damage lands in the silence after.

The man, in detail. **He has been running the Village Players for years.** Long enough to know every actor's contract, every patron in the canton, every Pirandello and Beckett and Coward by reputation if not by heart. Long enough to know that the morning is too short, the budget is too small, and the only thing that has ever saved a season has been a glorious failure. He is not a bad director. He is a tired one. The cynicism is technique. The compassion is real. Pragmatic, cynical, slightly ridiculous, slightly brave. He treats the play in front of him as a job, until the job turns into something he does not have a name for, and then he tries to make a play out of it anyway.

None of this needs a prop or a glance at the house. He simply behaves like a tired man at a rehearsal that has got away from him — leaning forward when something hooks him, looking at the floor when the stage shows more than he wants to see — and the audience reads themselves in him without noticing they are doing it.

The arc to score: **Act One** — he arrives furious that the morning is being wasted, ready to fight his Leading Man about a cook's cap. He thinks the Characters are mad and tries to throw them out. Then he starts to listen. **Act Two** — he believes, perhaps, that there is a play in this. He casts the parts. He summons Madame Pace by mistake. He hands the scene to the Leading Lady and the Leading Man. The accidental curtain falls and he calls it the right ending. The audience watches him decide that the worst hour of a young woman's life can be staged as scene one. **Act Three** — he is exhausted in a way that is no longer technique. He tries to stage a tragedy on an empty stage. He pushes the Father for clarity. **He sets the Boy-chair behind the fountain himself** — the moment he stops being audience and becomes accessory. Then a real shot rings out, and a real day has been lost. He says the line. He walks out. The audience hears their own thought, said aloud, by a man they have just spent two hours watching themselves through. Do not play him as a buffoon. Play him as a man who almost understands what he is watching, and walks out of the theatre without quite admitting it. The audience will do the same.

THE PLAY, AND HOW IT BEGINS

What it is. Pirandello's *Six Characters in Search of an Author* (1921). A theatre company's ordinary rehearsal is interrupted by six figures — a Father, a Mother, a Step-Daughter, a Son, and two silent children — who claim to be unfinished Characters, abandoned by their author, and demand that their drama be staged. The evening is the collision between their fixed, unbearable story and a working company's attempt to turn it into theatre.

This production. Set in Lausanne, played by **nine live performers** with **two stage objects** in place of the two youngest children (a coat-and-chair for the Boy, a wrapped bundle for the Child), on three stripped settings — **no projection, no screen**. One interval, after Act One; the second half plays unbroken to the fountain.

How it opens. The curtain is already up on a half-lit working stage. The Village Players are dragging themselves into a rehearsal of another Pirandello play, *Mixing It Up* — the Manager arrives tired and behind, there is the business of the cook's cap, the Players bicker. Then the working lights soften to a strange amber: the Door-keeper carries in the Boy-chair, and the four family Characters walk on, the Step-Daughter already holding the Child-bundle. From that entrance the play has begun, and it does not let go.

HOW TO READ THIS BOOK

Everything this role says and does, in performance order, grouped by act and by part. Each speech is preceded by a short **CUE** — the tail of the line before it — so you can find your entrance. Where the role doubles a function, the function is printed beside the line (*as Prompter*, and so on); chorus lines the company speaks together keep their group tag (*All Three Players*). Blocking lives in the bracketed action cues inside the speeches. The text is pulled byte-for-byte from the Director's Copy, so it always matches the current script.

Act One — The Family

PART I *The Rehearsal*

14 SPEECHES · 243 WORDS

THE MANAGER *[throwing the morning's letters onto the table]*. No. No. Not another one. If it's a bill, a complaint, or a note from somebody with "thoughts about the theatre," burn it before I read it.

| **CUE** *Player 2*: It's all three, sir. The same envelope.

THE MANAGER *[looking round the half-lit room]*. And who opened this room? It looks like a waiting room for actors nobody called back.

| **CUE** *Player 1*: Then for once we are perfectly cast.

THE MANAGER. Don't be charming, sir — it costs extra, and we can't afford it. *[to the Property Man]* A little light, please — if the house has any left to spare us this evening.

| **CUE** *Player 2*: Half light. It's what's left.

THE MANAGER. Half light, half a company, half a budget. *[a beat]* We're ready for Pirandello. *[quietly, almost to himself]* God help us.

| **CUE** *The Manager*: ... a company, half a budget. We're ready for Pirandello. God help us.

THE MANAGER *[clapping his hands]*. Come along! Second act of "Mixing It Up" — and play it, this once, as if you wanted the public back for the third.

| **CUE** *Player 3*: "Leo Gala's house. A curious room serving as dining-room and study."

THE MANAGER *[to the Property Man]*. Fix up the old red room.

| **CUE** *Player 2*: The red room is blue now. We painted over it in March.

THE MANAGER. Then make it red.

| **CUE** *Player 3*: ... cook's cap and apron, is busy beating an egg in a cup..."

THE MANAGER *[before anyone can object]*. Yes — real eggs, if the budget runs to it. *[it does not]* Mime them.

| **CUE** *Player 1*: Excuse me. Must I absolutely wear a cook's cap?

THE MANAGER *[annoyed]*. It says so there. *[pointing to the "book"]*

| **CUE** *Player 2*: Fifteen years. And the cap is what finally finishes you.

THE MANAGER *[rounding on him]*. Ridiculous? Of course it's ridiculous — that is the whole job. We are paid to make ridiculous things look inevitable. So put on the cap, beat the egg, and become the shell.

| **CUE** *Player 1*: The shell?

THE MANAGER. Empty, fragile, and cracked before the public arrives. Try not to overplay it. *[more quietly]* And is it my fault France keeps its good comedies for Paris and sends us Pirandello — whom nobody understands, least of all the people paid to perform him?

| **CUE** *Player 1*: Let the record show I wear it under protest.

THE MANAGER. The record is noted. The record is always noted. *[clapping]* Chair, book — and somebody pretend we are a theatre.

CUE *Player 3:* ... mended, and I'd rather not be hoarse for my first proper season.

THE MANAGER. Yes, yes — in, in.

CUE *Player 3:* Do we ever rehearse anything real?

THE MANAGER. Real? God forbid. Real things ruin a rehearsal.

PART II *The Interruption*

31 SPEECHES · 366 WORDS

CUE *Player 1:* ... désolé to interrupt; I know you don't like the morning's work disturbed...

THE MANAGER *[rudely]*. Eh? What is it?

CUE *Player 1:* ... for you, sir. I did tell them you were busy. They insisted.

THE MANAGER *[without looking up]*. I am rehearsing, and you know perfectly well no one's allowed to come in during rehearsals! *[Turning to the CHARACTERS.]* Who are you, please? What do you want?

CUE *The Father:* Actually... we have come here in search of an author...

THE MANAGER *[half angry, half amazed]*. An author? What author?

CUE *The Father:* Any author, sir.

THE MANAGER. But there's no author here. We are not rehearsing a new piece.

CUE *The Father:* Yes, but if the author isn't here... unless you would be willing...

THE MANAGER. You are trying to be funny. We have neither the time nor the budget for funny.

CUE *The Step-Daughter:* ... be your fortune, sir — if you have the nerve for us.

THE MANAGER. Will you oblige me by going away? *Allez*, please. We haven't time to waste with mad people. We have our own.

CUE *The Father:* ... things seem true? We are true already. We only lack the stage.

THE MANAGER *[interpreting the rising anger of the COMPANY]*. But I beg you to believe, my dear sir, that the actor's profession is a noble one. If today's playwrights give us stupid comedies to play and puppets instead of real people, remember — we are proud to have given life to immortal works on these very boards. *[The ACTORS, satisfied, applaud their MANAGER.]*

CUE *The Step-Daughter:* ... using that word for years. Ask my mother how true it sounded.

THE MANAGER. What do you mean? A moment ago you were saying the opposite.

CUE *The Father:* ... anyone that imagination gives bodies to things that would otherwise remain invisible.

THE MANAGER. Very well — but where does all this take us?

CUE *The Father:* ... we were born this way. Characters. Alive. And left without a stage.

THE MANAGER *[with feigned comic dismay]*. So you and these other friends of yours have been born characters?

CUE *The Father*: ... drama, as you can guess from this woman here veiled in black.

THE MANAGER *[losing patience at last and almost indignant]*. Oh, enough! Out, please! Clear out of here! *[To PROPERTY MAN.]* For Heaven's sake, turn them out!

CUE *The Father*: No, no, look here, we...

THE MANAGER *[roaring]*. We come here to work, you know.

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: He has said all this to himself before. Many times.

THE MANAGER. That is quite all right. But what do you want here, all of you?

CUE *The Father*: We want to live.

THE MANAGER. For Eternity?

CUE *The Father*: ... and your actors are willing, we can soon arrange it among ourselves.

THE MANAGER *[annoyed]*. But what do you want to arrange? We don't arrange things here. Here we play dramas, comedies, and — once a year, against my better judgment — a musical revue. Not whatever this is.

CUE *The Father*: Exactly! That is just why we have come to you.

THE MANAGER. And where is the "book"?

CUE *Player 1, Player 2 & Player 3*: Bravo! Well done! Encore!

THE MANAGER. Silence! This isn't a café concert, you know! *[Turning to the FATHER in consternation.]* Is she mad?

CUE *Player 1, Player 2 & Player 3*: Is it true? Has she really fainted?

THE MANAGER. Quick, a chair! Here! *[One of the ACTORS brings a chair, the OTHERS proffer assistance. The MOTHER tries to prevent the FATHER from lifting the veil which covers her face.]*

CUE *The Mother*: ... you, sir. Stop him. I cannot bear what he wants to do.

THE MANAGER *[dumbfounded]*. I don't understand at all. Is this lady your wife? *[To the FATHER.]*

CUE *The Father*: Yes, gentlemen: my wife!

THE MANAGER. But how can she be a widow if you are alive? *[The ACTORS find relief for their astonishment in a loud laugh.]*

CUE *Player 3*: For once.

THE MANAGER *[beginning to get really interested — leaning slightly forward, the way an audience member does when they have started to listen]*. Let's hear them out. Listen!

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: ... for this part of it. I do not blush, however. He does.

THE MANAGER *[the audience's confusion, on stage]*. I don't understand this at all.

CUE *Player 2*: ... — mais sérieusement — are we going to rehearse today, or not?

THE MANAGER. Of course, of course; but let's hear them out.

CUE *Player 2*: ... The rest of us are working actors. We have rent to pay.

THE MANAGER *[to FATHER]*. You must please explain yourself quite clearly. *[Sits down.]*

CUE *The Father*: ... keep me quiet. And that alone kept me in a constant rage.

THE MANAGER. And why didn't you send him away then — this secretary of yours?

| **CUE** *The Father:* ... had these damned aspirations toward a moral sanity I never quite reach.

THE MANAGER. Yes, please stop it, for Heaven's sake.

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* ... paper parcel: a fine straw hat, a bouquet of flowers. For me.

THE MANAGER. A bit discursive this, you know!

| **CUE** *The Father:* Literature indeed! This is life, this is passion!

THE MANAGER. It may be, but it won't act.

| **CUE** *The Father:* ... she has to forgive me. And she would rather burn than forgive.

THE MANAGER [*a little too quickly*]. Let's come to the point. This is only discussion.

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* ... these two children here, sitting up at night sewing Madame Pace's dresses.

THE MANAGER. And one day you met there...

| **CUE** *The Father:* ... as it were. The image of his father. Hardly talks at all.

THE MANAGER. Oh, we'll cut him out. You've no notion what a nuisance boys are on the stage...

PART III *The Bargain*

12 SPEECHES · 173 WORDS

THE MANAGER. Damn it... there is something in what you say. I don't like it, but it interests me.

| **CUE** *The Father:* You be quiet!

THE MANAGER [*reflecting*]. It's new... hem... yes... You've got a nerve, though — to come here and fling it at me like this.

| **CUE** *The Father:* You will understand, sir, born as we are for the stage...

THE MANAGER. Are you amateur actors then? Because we, sir, are a professional company, with a season to fill.

| **CUE** *The Father:* No. I say born for the stage, because...

THE MANAGER. Oh, nonsense. You're an old hand, you know.

| **CUE** *The Father:* ... act like amateurs. We live the roles life has cast us in.

THE MANAGER. Well, well, that will do. But you see, without an author... I could give you the address of an author if you like...

| **CUE** *The Father:* ... the author. You need not invent us — only give us form.

THE MANAGER. I? What are you talking about?

| **CUE** *The Father:* Yes, you, you! Why not?

THE MANAGER. Because I have never been an author: that's why.

| **CUE** *The Father:* ... by listening. We are already here. You need only take us down.

THE MANAGER. It won't do.

CUE *The Father*: What? When you see us live our drama...

THE MANAGER. Yes, that's all right. But you want someone to write it.

CUE *The Father*: ... enough to sketch it out at first, and then try it over.

THE MANAGER. Well... I am almost tempted. It's a bit of an idea. One might have a shot at it.

CUE *The Father*: ... will come out of it. I can give you one, at once...

THE MANAGER *[he is hooked, in spite of himself; the schedule he came in trying to defend is no longer in his mind]*. God help me, it tempts me. I ought to throw you out — and instead I want to see the first scene. Come to my office. We'll see what can be done.

CUE *The Father*: ... doubt about it. They had better come with us too, hadn't they?

THE MANAGER. Yes, yes. Come on! come on! *[Moves away and then turning to the ACTORS.]* Be punctual, please! *[MANAGER and the Six CHARACTERS cross the stage and go off. The other ACTORS remain, looking at one another in astonishment.]*

Act Two — The Theatre

PART I *The Setup*

36 SPEECHES · 740 WORDS

CUE *The Father*: ... Come here for a minute! We've arranged everything. It's all fixed up.

THE MANAGER [*also excited*]. If you please, young lady, there are one or two points to settle still. Will you come along?

The MOTHER hides her face in her hands. From the dressing-rooms and the little door at the back of the stage the ACTORS and STAGE MANAGER return, followed by the PROPERTY MAN, and the PROMPTER. At the same moment, THE MANAGER comes out of his office, accompanied by the FATHER and the STEP-DAUGHTER.

CUE *Player 3*: ... stopped writing it down. I don't want a record of this one.

THE MANAGER [*trying to take the rehearsal back, his director's voice returning*]. Come on, come on, ladies and gentlemen! Right — you there, machinist!

CUE *Player 1*: Yes, sir.

THE MANAGER. Fix up the white parlor with the floral decorations. Two wings and a drop with a door will do. Hurry up!

The MACHINIST runs off at once to prepare the scene, and arranges it while THE MANAGER talks with the STAGE MANAGER, the PROPERTY MAN, and the PROMPTER on matters of detail.

CUE *The Manager*: ... Two wings and a drop with a door will do. Hurry up!

THE MANAGER [*to PROPERTY MAN*]. Just have a look, and see if there isn't a sofa or divan in the wardrobe...

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: ... It was yellow, ornamented with flowers — very large! and most comfortable!

THE MANAGER. It doesn't matter. Use the one we've got.

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: Doesn't matter? It's most important!

THE MANAGER. We're only trying it now. Please don't interfere. [*To PROPERTY MAN.*] See if we've got a shop window — long and narrowish.

CUE *Player 2*: There's that little gilt one.

THE MANAGER. That'll do fine.

CUE *Player 2*: That's all right, Miss. We've got any amount of them.

THE MANAGER [*to the STEP-DAUGHTER*]. We want some clothes pegs too, don't we?

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: Yes. Several. There were always several. On the wall by the screen.

THE MANAGER. See how many we've got and bring them all.

CUE *Player 2*: Right.

THE MANAGER *[to PROMPTER]*. Take your seat. Look here: this is the outline of the scenes, act by act. *[Hands him some sheets of paper.]* And now I'm going to ask you to do something out of the ordinary.

| **CUE** *Player 3:* Take it down in shorthand? Sir — in shorthand?

THE MANAGER *[pleasantly surprised]*. Exactly! Can you do shorthand?

| **CUE** *Player 3:* Yes, a little.

THE MANAGER. Good! *[Turning to a STAGE HAND.]* Go and get some paper from my office, plenty, as much as you can find. *[The STAGE HAND goes off, and soon returns with a handful of paper which he gives to the PROMPTER.]*

| **CUE** *The Manager:* ... some paper from my office, plenty, as much as you can find.

THE MANAGER *[to PROMPTER]*. You follow the scenes as we play them, and try and get the points down, at any rate the most important ones. *[Then addressing the ACTORS.]* Clear the stage, ladies and gentlemen! Come over here *[Pointing to the left.]* and listen attentively.

| **CUE** *Player 2:* But, excuse me, we...

THE MANAGER *[guessing her thought]*. Don't worry! You won't have to improvise.

| **CUE** *Player 1:* What do we do, then — sit and watch?

THE MANAGER. Nothing. For the moment you just watch and listen. Everybody will get his part written out afterwards. At present we're going to try the thing as best we can. They're going to act now.

| **CUE** *The Father:* We? What do you mean, if you please, by a rehearsal?

THE MANAGER. A rehearsal for them. *[Points to the ACTORS.]*

| **CUE** *The Father:* But since we are the characters...

THE MANAGER. All right: "characters" then, if you insist on calling yourselves such. But here, my dear sir, the characters don't act. Here the actors do the acting. The characters are there, in the "book" *[Pointing towards PROMPTER'S box.]* — when there is a "book"!

| **CUE** *The Father:* ... these gentlemen here are fortunate enough to have us alive before them...

THE MANAGER. Oh this is grand! You want to come before the public yourselves then?

| **CUE** *The Father:* As we are...

THE MANAGER. I can assure you it would be a magnificent spectacle!

| **CUE** *Player 1:* What is the use of us here, then?

THE MANAGER. You're not seriously going to pretend you can act? It makes me laugh! *[The ACTORS laugh.]* There, you see, they are laughing at the notion. But, by the way, I must cast the parts. That won't be difficult. They cast themselves. *[To the SECOND LADY LEAD.]* You play the Mother. *[To the FATHER.]* We must find her a name.

| **CUE** *The Father:* Amalia, sir.

THE MANAGER. But that is the real name of your wife. We don't want to call her by her real name.

| **CUE** *The Father:* ... say to you. Already I can hear my own words ring false...

THE MANAGER. Don't you worry about it. It'll be our job to find the right tones. And as for her name, if you want her to be Amalia, Amalia she is. If you don't like it, we'll find another! For the moment though, we'll call the characters in this way: *[To JUVENILE LEAD.]* You are the Son. *[To the LEADING LADY.]* You naturally are the Step-Daughter...

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* What? What? I — that woman there?

THE MANAGER *[angry].* What is there to laugh at?

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* No, no, excuse me... I'm not laughing at you...

THE MANAGER *[to STEP-DAUGHTER].* You should feel honored to be played by...

| **CUE** *The Father:* True. Here's the point. Look here, sir, our temperaments, our souls...

THE MANAGER. Temperament, soul — to hell with all that! Your soul, or whatever you like to call it, takes shape *here*: my actors give it body, voice, gesture. They have given voice to material far loftier than this little drama of yours — and if it holds the stage at all, the merit will be theirs.

| **CUE** *The Father:* ... as we are, with these bodies of ours, these features to see...

THE MANAGER *[cutting him short and out of patience].* Good heavens! The make-up will remedy all that, man, the make-up... On the stage, you as yourself cannot exist. The actor here acts you, and that's an end to it!

| **CUE** *The Father:* ... myself to be, in here. Whoever judges us ought to remember that.

THE MANAGER. Heavens! The man's starting to think about the critics now! Let them say what they like. It's up to us to put on the play if we can. *[Looking around.]* Come on! come on! Is the stage set? *[To the ACTORS and CHARACTERS.]* Stand back — stand back! Let me see, and don't let's lose any more time! *[To the STEP-DAUGHTER.]* Is it all right as it is now?

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* Well, to tell the truth, I don't recognize the scene.

THE MANAGER. My dear lady, you can't possibly suppose that we can construct that shop of Madame Pace piece by piece here? *[To the FATHER.]* You said a white room with flowered wall paper, didn't you?

| **CUE** *The Father:* Yes.

THE MANAGER. Well then. We've got the furniture right more or less. Bring that little table a bit further forward. *[The STAGE HANDS obey the order. To PROPERTY MAN.]* You go and find an envelope, if possible, a pale blue one; and give it to that gentleman. *[Indicates FATHER.]*

| **CUE** *Player 2:* An ordinary envelope?

THE MANAGER AND THE FATHER. Yes, yes, an ordinary envelope.

| **CUE** *Player 2:* At once, sir.

THE MANAGER. Ready, everyone! First scene — the Young Lady. *[The LEADING LADY comes forward.]* No, no, you must wait. I meant her *[Indicating the STEP-DAUGHTER.]* You just watch —

| **CUE** *Player 2:* ... live it too, you may be sure, as soon as I begin!

THE MANAGER *[with his hands to his head].* Ladies and gentlemen, if you please! No more useless discussions! Scene I: the young lady with Madame Pace: Oh! *[Looks around as if lost.]* And this Madame Pace, where is she?

| **CUE** *The Father:* She isn't with us, sir.

THE MANAGER. Then what the devil's to be done? I cannot rehearse a character who has not arrived.

| **CUE** *The Father:* But she is alive too.

THE MANAGER. Yes, but where is she?

| **CUE** *Player 1:* Our hats?

THE MANAGER. What are you going to do with the ladies' hats? [*The ACTORS laugh.*]

| **CUE** *The Father:* Exactly; just like that, on show.

THE MANAGER. May we know why?

PART II *The Apparition*

15 SPEECHES · 347 WORDS

| **CUE** *The Father:* It's she! I said so, didn't I? There she is!

THE MANAGER [*conquering his surprise, and then becoming indignant*]. What sort of a trick is this?

| **CUE** *The Father:* ... would be less true than the woman standing there. That is all.

THE MANAGER. Well? well?

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* ... and have my revenge. But for Madame it's quite a different matter.

THE MANAGER. Indeed? indeed? But here, you know, people have got to make themselves heard, my dear. Even we who are on the stage can't hear you. What will it be when the public's in the theatre? And anyway, you can very well speak up now among yourselves, since we shan't be present to listen to you as we are now. You've got to pretend to be alone in a room at the back of a shop where no one can hear you.

| **CUE** *The Manager:* ... at the back of a shop where no one can hear you.

THE MANAGER. What do you mean by no?

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* There's someone who will hear us if she speaks out loud.

THE MANAGER [*in consternation*]. What? Have you got someone else to spring on us now? [*The ACTORS burst out laughing.*]

| **CUE** *The Father:* ... me, I'll go there at once, so I can be quite ready.

THE MANAGER [*stopping him*]. No! Wait! wait! We must observe the conventions of the theatre. Before you are ready...

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* ... you, to act this scene. If he's ready, I'm more than ready.

THE MANAGER [*shouting*]. But, my dear young lady, first of all, we must have the scene between you and this lady... [*Indicates MADAME PACE.*] Do you understand?...

| **CUE** *Madame Pace:* ... sir — the book, she balance. Pace, she always balance the book.

THE MANAGER [*alarmed*]. What? What? She talks like that? [*The ACTORS burst out laughing again.*]

| **CUE** *Madame Pace:* ... bells, sir, in this town? Three time a week. Bom. Bom. Bom.

THE MANAGER. Perfect! Of course! Of course! Let her talk like that! Just what we want. Talk just like that, Madame, if you please! The effect's guaranteed — exactly what we needed, a bit of comic relief to lift all this

gloom. Of course she talks like that! Magnificent!

CUE *The Father*: ... on together, the whole thing is given away. Inevitably. As you see.

THE MANAGER. It doesn't matter. This is only a first rough sketch — just to get an idea of the various points of the scene, even confusedly... *[Turning to the MOTHER and leading her to her chair.]* Come along, my dear lady, sit down now, and let's get on with the scene...

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: ... voice! Say "Good afternoon, Miss" in that peculiar tone, that special tone...

THE MANAGER. Excuse me, but are you the Manager, or am I? *[To the FATHER, who looks undecided and perplexed.]* Get on with it, man! Go down there to the back of the stage. You needn't go off. Then come right forward here.

CUE *The Manager*: ... of the stage. You needn't go off. Then come right forward here.

THE MANAGER *[sotto voce, quickly to the PROMPTER in his box]*. Ready! ready? Get ready to write now.

CUE *Player 1*: I say... those are our hats, you know.

THE MANAGER *[furious]*. Silence! silence! Don't try and be funny, if you please... We're playing the scene now I'd have you notice. *[To the STEP-DAUGHTER.]* Begin again, please!

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: ... of what I've said. I must forget that I am dressed so...

THE MANAGER *[interrupting and turning to the PROMPTER]*. Stop a minute! Stop! Don't write that down. Cut out that last bit. *[Then to the FATHER and STEP-DAUGHTER.]* Fine! it's going fine! *[To the FATHER only.]* And now you can go on as we arranged. *[To the ACTORS.]* Pretty good that scene, where he offers her the hat, eh?

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: The best's coming now. Why can't we go on?

THE MANAGER. Have a little patience! *[To the ACTORS.]* Of course, it must be treated rather lightly.

PART III *The Substitution*

39 SPEECHES · 625 WORDS

CUE *Player 1*: Why, yes! I'll prepare my entrance.

THE MANAGER *[to LEADING LADY]*. See here! The scene between you and Madame Pace is finished. I'll have it written out properly after. You remain here... oh, where are you going?

CUE *Player 2*: One minute. I want to put my hat on again.

THE MANAGER. Good! You stay here with your head bowed down a bit.

CUE *Player 2*: But I shall be. And much more effectively than you.

THE MANAGER *[to STEP-DAUGHTER]*. Be quiet please, and watch! You'll be able to learn something. *[Clapping his hands.]* Come on! come on! Entrance, please! *[The door at rear of stage opens, and the LEADING MAN enters with the lively manner of an old gallant. The rendering of the scene by the ACTORS from the very first words is seen to be quite a different thing, though it has not in any way the air of a parody. Naturally, the STEP-DAUGHTER and the FATHER, not being able to recognize themselves in the LEADING LADY and the LEADING MAN, who deliver their words in different tones and with a different psychology, express, sometimes with smiles, sometimes with gestures, the impression they receive.]*

CUE *The Father*: No! no!

THE MANAGER *[furious]*. Silence! And you please just stop that laughing. If we go on like this, we'll never finish.

| **CUE** *The Father*: Yes, yes, the manner, the tone...

THE MANAGER. Nonsense! Rubbish! Stand aside and let me see the action.

| **CUE** *Player 1*: ... we mean, then at the very least let me find the door.

THE MANAGER. Don't listen to them, for Heaven's sake! Do it again! It goes fine. *[Waiting for the ACTORS to begin again.]* Well?

| **CUE** *Player 1*: ... is not the first time that you have come here, is it?

THE MANAGER. Good — but not so heavily. *[Acts it himself.]* And you say: "No, sir."

| **CUE** *Player 1*: You've been here before, more than once.

THE MANAGER. No, no, stop! Let her nod "yes" first. "You've been here before, eh?" *[The LEADING LADY lifts up her head slightly and closes her eyes as though in disgust. Then she inclines her head twice.]*

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter*: Oh my God!

THE MANAGER *[turning round]*. What's the matter?

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter*: Nothing, nothing!

THE MANAGER *[to LEADING MAN]*. Go on!

| **CUE** *Player 1*: ... to be so shy, is there? May I take off your hat?

THE MANAGER *[low, firm, to the players]*. Don't stop. Don't stop. We're past the worst of it. Carry on!

| **CUE** *Player 2*: ... of what I've said. I must forget that I am dressed so...

THE MANAGER *[satisfied, to the PROMPTER]*. Good. Good. Get that down. We'll skip the back-and-forth on the mourning — straight through to the next beat.

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter*: He didn't say "I'm frightfully sorry."

THE MANAGER. We've done that bit. Move on.

| **CUE** *Player 2*: ... five feet away correcting every breath. Either they sit or I sit.

THE MANAGER *[tired]*. They will sit down.

| **CUE** *Player 1*: Neither am I. I am through with this scene.

THE MANAGER *[shouting to STEP-DAUGHTER]*. Silence! for once and all, I tell you!

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter*: Forgive me! forgive me!

THE MANAGER. You haven't any manners: that's what it is! You go too far.

| **CUE** *The Father*: Yes, it's true, but excuse her...

THE MANAGER. Excuse what? It's absolutely disgusting.

| **CUE** *The Father*: Yes, sir, but believe me, it has such a strange effect when...

THE MANAGER. Strange? Why strange? Where is it strange?

| **CUE** *The Father*: ... — this gentleman here, this lady; but they are certainly not us!

THE MANAGER. I should hope not. Evidently they cannot be you, if they are actors.

CUE *The Father*: ... longer ours — and we must stand here and watch it happen.

THE MANAGER. But naturally, inevitably. I've told you so already.

CUE *The Father*: Yes, I understand... I understand...

THE MANAGER. Well then, let's have no more of it! [*Turning to the ACTORS.*] We'll have the rehearsals by ourselves, afterwards, in the ordinary way. I never could stand rehearsing with the author present. He's never satisfied! [*Turning to FATHER and STEP-DAUGHTER.*] Come on! Let's get on with it again; and try and see if you can't keep from laughing.

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: ... more. There's a nice little bit coming for me now: you'll see.

THE MANAGER. Well then: when she says "Don't think any more of what I've said. I must forget, etc.," you [*Addressing the FATHER.*] come in sharp with "I understand, I understand"; and then you ask her...

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: What?

THE MANAGER. Why she is in mourning.

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: ... said? "Ah well," he said, "then let's take this little dress off."

THE MANAGER. Great! Just what we want, to make a riot in the theatre!

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: But it's the truth!

THE MANAGER. What does that matter? Acting is our business here. Truth up to a certain point, but no further.

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: What do you want to do then?

THE MANAGER. You'll see, you'll see! Leave it to me.

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: ... speaks to a child — well, let's take this little dress off.

THE MANAGER [*running his hands through his hair*]. For Heaven's sake! What are you saying?

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: The truth. The truth.

THE MANAGER. It may be. I don't deny it, and I can understand all your horror; but you must surely see that you can't have this kind of thing on the stage. It won't go.

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: ... eh? Very well! I'm much obliged to you — but I'm off!

THE MANAGER. Now be reasonable! Don't lose your temper!

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: ... in good taste. But I want to act my part. My part.

THE MANAGER [*annoyed, shaking his shoulders*]. Ah! Just your part! But there are other parts than yours — his [*Indicating the Father.*] and hers [*Indicating the Mother.*]. On the stage you can't have one character overshadowing all the others. The thing is to pack them into a neat little framework and act what isactable. From your point of view, every character would tell the public all his troubles in a nice monologue. [*softening, sitting on the edge of the table*] You must restrain yourself, my dear — in your own interest, too — because this fury of yours may make a bad impression.

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: ... true. But remember those others mean him for me all the same.

THE MANAGER [*not understanding*]. What? The others? What do you mean?

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: ... was even born. Look at him, sir. See if it isn't true.

THE MANAGER. Well, well! And does the weight of so much responsibility seem nothing to you? Give him a chance to act it, to get it over!

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* ... do you want to see it flash out as it really did?

THE MANAGER. Of course! That's just what I do want, so I can use as much of it as is possible.

| **CUE** *The Mother:* No! No! Don't permit it, sir, don't permit it!

THE MANAGER. But it's only to try it.

| **CUE** *The Mother:* I can't bear it. I can't.

THE MANAGER. But since it has happened already... I don't understand!

| **CUE** *The Father:* ... give it up. And you, sir, cannot fairly spare me it either.

THE MANAGER. I never said I didn't want to act it. It will form, in fact, the nucleus of the whole first act right up to her surprise. [*Indicates the MOTHER.*]

| **CUE** *The Mother:* ... you brute! She is my daughter! Don't you see she's my daughter?

THE MANAGER [*walking backwards towards the footlights — the way a satisfied audience member would, if a satisfied audience member could walk*]. Fine. Fine. Damned good. And then, of course — curtain.

| **CUE** *The Father:* Yes, of course, because that's the way it really happened.

THE MANAGER [*convinced and pleased*]. Oh, yes, no doubt about it. Curtain here, curtain!

| *At the reiterated cry of THE MANAGER, THE MACHINIST lets the curtain down, leaving THE MANAGER and THE FATHER in front of it before the footlights.*

| **CUE** *The Manager:* Oh, yes, no doubt about it. Curtain here, curtain!

THE MANAGER. The darned idiot! I said "curtain" to show the act should end there, and he goes and lets it down in earnest. [*To the FATHER, while he pulls the curtain back to go on to the stage again.*] Yes, yes, it's all right. Effect certain! That's the right ending. I'll guarantee the first act at any rate.

Act Three — The Question

PART I *The Trap*

22 SPEECHES · 250 WORDS

THE MANAGER *[shaking his shoulders after a brief pause]*. Ah yes: the second act! Leave it to me, leave it all to me as we arranged, and you'll see! It'll go fine!

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter*: Our entry into his house in spite of him...

THE MANAGER *[out of patience]*. Leave it to me, I tell you!

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter*: ... doesn't matter. The more harm done us, the more remorse for him.

THE MANAGER *[impatiently]*. I understand! Good Heavens! I understand! I'm taking it into account.

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter*: ... get at his heart, the more distant and aloof does he become.

THE MANAGER. Are we going to begin this second act or not?

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter*: ... action take place in the garden, as you suggest. It isn't possible!

THE MANAGER. Why not?

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter*: ... the part of that poor dazed-looking boy there which takes place indoors.

THE MANAGER. Maybe! On the other hand, you will understand — we can't change scenes three or four times in one act.

| **CUE** *Player 1*: ... change scenes like that once. When theatres had more hands than rules.

THE MANAGER. Yes, when the public was up to the level of that child there.

| **CUE** *The Father*: ... illusion. Please. Don't use that word. It is particularly painful for us.

THE MANAGER *[astounded]*. And why, if you please?

| **CUE** *The Father*: It is painful. Cruel. Really cruel. And you should understand that.

THE MANAGER. But why? What ought we to say then? The illusion, I tell you, sir, which we've got to create for the audience...

| **CUE** *Player 1*: With our acting.

THE MANAGER. The illusion of a reality.

| **CUE** *The Father*: ... has to give, as the gentleman says, a perfect illusion of reality.

THE MANAGER. Precisely —!

| **CUE** *The Father*: ... , as we are, have no other reality outside of this illusion...

THE MANAGER *[astonished, looking at his ACTORS, who are also amazed]*. And what does that mean?

| **CUE** *The Father*: ... way. Just think it over. Can you tell me who you are?

THE MANAGER *[perplexed, half smiling]*. What? Who am I? I am myself.

| **CUE** *The Father*: ... were to tell you that that isn't true. Because you and I...

THE MANAGER. I should say you were mad —! [*The ACTORS laugh.*]

| **CUE** *The Father:* ... thing you see. You see — I've caught you in a trap.

THE MANAGER [*annoyed*]. But we've had all this over once before. Do you want to begin again?

| **CUE** *The Father:* ... your actors. And to ask you, seriously, once again. Who are you?

THE MANAGER [*astonished and irritated, turning to his ACTORS*]. If this fellow here hasn't got a nerve! A man who calls himself a character comes and asks me who I am!

| **CUE** *The Father:* ... I'm not speaking of you now — may very well be nobody.

THE MANAGER. Yes, but you are asking these questions of me, the boss, the manager! Do you understand?

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* His reality. He always knew exactly where to find me.

THE MANAGER [*rattled now, and covering it*]. Well. Well. And where does all this take us anyway?

| **CUE** *The Father:* ... you, sir, have no more than that. You only think you do.

THE MANAGER [*mocking him because the idea has unsettled him*]. Ah, excellent! Then you'll be saying next that you, with this comedy of yours that you brought here to act, are truer and more real than I am.

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* ... was real that afternoon. With his hundred francs. He was very real.

THE MANAGER. Ah, really?

| **CUE** *The Father:* Why, I thought you'd understand that from the beginning.

THE MANAGER. More real than I?

| **CUE** *The Father:* If your reality can change from one day to another...

THE MANAGER. But everyone knows it can change. It is always changing, the same as anyone else's.

PART II *The Refusal*

16 SPEECHES · 610 WORDS

THE MANAGER. Oh for God's sake, will you at least finish with this philosophising, and let's try and shape this comedy which you yourself have brought me here? You argue and philosophise a bit too much, my dear sir. You know you seem to me almost, almost... [*Stops and looks him over from head to foot.*] Ah, by the way, I think you introduced yourself to me as a — what shall we call it — a "character," created by an author who did not afterward care to make a drama of his own creations.

| **CUE** *The Father:* It is the simple truth, sir.

THE MANAGER. Nonsense! Cut that out, please! None of us believes it, because it isn't a thing one can believe seriously. If you want to know, it seems to me you are trying to imitate the manner of a certain author whom I heartily detest — I warn you — although I have unfortunately bound myself to put on one of his works. In fact, I was just starting to rehearse it when you arrived. [*Turning to the Actors.*] And this is what we've gained — out of the frying-pan into the fire!

| **CUE** *Player 1:* I would like to go home. Quietly. Now.

THE MANAGER [*sharp now, no longer amused*]. Sir — plainer. Shorter. We have actors here who'd like to know what they're being asked to play. Tonight, if possible.

CUE *The Father*: I am not philosophising, sir. I am explaining.

THE MANAGER. Look here. Look here. You're off again — philosophising worse than ever.

CUE *The Father*: ... Pain is the one thing your stage can rehearse and never feel.

THE MANAGER [*slaps the table*]. I'd like to know if anyone has ever heard of a character who climbs right out of his part and makes speeches the way you do. Have you ever heard of such a thing? I haven't.

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: Listen to him. Even now he is the author.

THE MANAGER. Yes, yes, I know this.

CUE *The Son*: No, nothing!

THE MANAGER. You too get over the mark occasionally, my dear sir, if I may say so.

CUE *The Father*: I? When? Where? Give me one instance.

THE MANAGER. Always! Continuously! Then there's this insistence of yours in trying to make us believe you are a character. And then too, you must really argue and philosophize less, you know, much less.

CUE *The Father*: ... mere fact, as she wants. It would destroy my reason for being.

THE MANAGER. Your *raison d'être*! Oh, we're going ahead fine! First she starts off, and then you jump in. At this rate, we'll never finish.

CUE *The Father*: ... of the parts you assign us each one's sacrifice isn't too great.

THE MANAGER. You've got to understand that you can't go on arguing at your own pleasure. Drama is action, sir, action and not damned philosophy.

CUE *The Father*: ... and philosophizing as everybody does when he is considering his own torments.

THE MANAGER. If the drama permits — which at this rate, sir, I doubt it will. For Heaven's sake, man, let's get along and come to the scene.

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: ... house. You said, before, you couldn't change the scene every five minutes.

THE MANAGER. Of course not. What we've got to do is combine and group all the facts into one simultaneous, close-knit action. We can't have it as you want, with your little brother wandering like a ghost from room to room, hiding behind doors and meditating a project which — what did you say it did to him?

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: ... away. He has not eaten properly since we came into that house.

THE MANAGER. Well, it may be. And then at the same time, you want the little girl there to be playing in the garden... one in the house, and the other in the garden: isn't that it?

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: ... hand. She loved the little flowers, and would show them to me.

THE MANAGER. Well then, we'll have it in the garden. Everything shall happen in the garden — we'll group the other scenes there. [*Calls a Stage Hand.*] A backcloth with trees, and something to do as a fountain basin. Good — you've fixed it up. [*To Step-Daughter.*] This is just to give an idea, of course. The Boy, instead of hiding behind the doors, will wander about here in the garden, hiding behind the trees. It's going to be rather difficult to find a child to do the scene with you where she shows you the flowers. [*To the Boy.*] Come forward a little. Let's try it. It's a nice business, this lad. What's the matter with him? We'll have to give him a word or two to say. [*He stands. He picks up the Boy-chair himself and walks it across the stage. This is the pivot of his arc: until this gesture he has been the audience, watching from a remove. From this gesture forward he is the audience's complicity*

made physical. He places the Boy-chair behind the fountain basin, where it is partly hidden by the rim. The audience must see the move land.] Hide here — like that. Show your head a little, as if looking for someone.

CUE *The Son:* Delighted! Delighted! I don't ask for anything better.

THE MANAGER *[at once stopping him].* No! No! Where are you going? Wait a bit!

CUE *The Son:* ... to do with this affair. Let me go please! Let me go!

THE MANAGER. What do you mean by saying you've got nothing to do with this?

PART III *The Fountain*

15 SPEECHES · 131 WORDS

CUE *The Step-Daughter:* ... wait... First of all, the baby has to go to the fountain...

THE MANAGER. Yes, yes of course; that's it. Both at the same time.

CUE *The Son:* ... understand? Not the garden. Nothing about this ever happened in the garden.

THE MANAGER. It doesn't matter. Haven't I told you we've got to group the action?

CUE *The Son:* Ah! she's at it too: to re-act her part!

THE MANAGER. Exactly! And it seems to me that you should be grateful to them for their interest.

CUE *The Father:* That is true, absolutely true. You must see that.

THE MANAGER *[to SECOND LADY LEAD and JUVENILE LEAD].* He's right! Move away from them!

CUE *The Son:* Do as you like. I'm out of this!

THE MANAGER. Be quiet, you, will you? And let me hear your mother! *[To MOTHER.]* You were saying you had entered...

CUE *The Mother:* It's true, true. That's how it was.

THE MANAGER. Well now, we've got to do this bit between you and him. It's indispensable.

CUE *The Son:* ... who made us could not bear to stage this. Neither will I.

THE MANAGER. Man alive! You came here...

CUE *The Son:* He did! I didn't!

THE MANAGER. Aren't you here now?

CUE *The Son:* ... that did happen, but also things that have never happened at all.

THE MANAGER. Well, tell me then what did happen. You went out of your room without saying a word?

CUE *The Son:* Without a word, so as to avoid a scene!

THE MANAGER. And then what did you do?

CUE *The Son:* Nothing... walking in the garden...

THE MANAGER *[coming closer to him, interested by his extraordinary reserve].* Well, well... walking in the garden...

CUE *The Son:* Why on earth do you insist? It's horrible!

THE MANAGER *[slowly observing the glance and turning towards the SON with increasing apprehension].* The baby?

| **CUE** *The Father:* She was following him at the moment...

THE MANAGER *[to the SON anxiously].* And then you...

| **CUE** *The Mother:* My son! My son! Help! Help!

THE MANAGER *[pushing the PLAYERS aside while they lift up the Boy-chair and carry it off, handling it as if it were the Boy's body — heavy, careful, terrible].* Is he really wounded?

| **CUE** *The Father:* Pretence? Reality, sir, reality!

THE MANAGER *[no commentary, no irony].* Pretence? Reality? *[He looks at the place where the Boy-chair stood.]* To hell with it all. *[He turns and leaves the stage the way a man leaves a theatre.]*